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"Dinosaurs Love Chips"

by Matt Mills

A bubbly, rambunctious, but unprepared fifth grader, ELLIE FAE, walks up to the front of her classroom.

Thank you, Miss Anderson. And thank you all for listening to my big important fifth grade science report that I definitely remembered to do.

Okay. So. What am I going to talk about today? That is a great question, Ellie Fae. Thank you, Ellie. You're welcome, Ellie. So, Ellie—what are we going to talk about today? …I'm not actually asking this, of course, because I know the answer. It's just you that don't. Uh. Know what I'm going to talk about today. That is… okay, what we're—I'm about to say what I'm talking about today, because it is… um… dinosaurs!

Yeah. Bet you didn't see that coming. Well you should've, 'cause I've known for a very long time of research and time that my project is about dinosaurs. So here it uh, finally goes… in a minute. After I'm done, uh. Transitionaling. Yeah. Just one more transitional and then I'll start, okay? Okay. I say it's okay. Okay. Ready? Okay. Here it goes. In three. Two. One. Now here it goes. …Okay here it is. Finally. For real. Here's how my science report goes… this is it. Listen. I'm starting now…

Dinosaurs were born a really, really long time ago. Like, before the 1980s. Dinosaurs are so old they aren't allowed to vote. If they did, they would only vote for Godzilla, and that is really unfair.

Ellie uses blank easel paper as a visual aid.

As you can see here, this blank page shows that dinosaurs live in a democracy, which means that once a week they get together and vote on who gets to eat the most cats. Dinosaurs eat meat, but they also eat vegetables and chips and tomatoes, so science considers them alleatvores. Dinosaurs are bad at chopsticks, but they're also bad at forks. They eat with their teeth and anything they can't pick up gets blended into a shake for dessert. Ummm… what else. I just—my brain is so full of dinosaur knowledge! It's hard to get it all out. Yeah. It's like… when there's too much stuff in a drawer. Does that ever happen to you? Dinosaurs don't have drawers. That's a fun fact. Hmmm…

Ellie spots the world map dropdown, rushes over to it, and unfurls her new visual aid.

As you can see here on this map, dinosaurs rode an asteroid to Earth during the Crustaceans period. Then they settled all over, bringing their love of fast food and opera to the whole planet. It was easy for them, too, because their legs were taller than mountains, and they liked the way the trees itched their legs when they walked. Stepping in lakes didn't bother them

as much as it bothers my brother, either. Dinosaurs are good at walking and hate couch potatoes. They hate couch potatoes so much that they don't even eat them—they just chew on them like greasy gum. Dinosaurs don't chew gum, but the world would be a better place if they did, because their breath smells.

Dinosaurs believe in cannibalism, which is where rich people get to make money and poor people get to work. They don't like taxes but they do them anyway. One time, a dinosaur tried to not pay his taxes, but a nice older dinosaur talked him into it. Dinosaurs have a strong sense of community and they always talk about their problems with people who know better.

Dinosaurs made a bunch of our land usable by building basketball courts, skate parks, and jungle gyms. Even though they're too busy at the office to have fun, they still like building fun things so they can feel fun, even though they're not. In fact, dinosaur brains are missing the part where fun happens. They also can't cry, but some dinosaurs have learned how to cry from watching Disney movies. Dinosaurs love life and all of the feelings that come with it. They will hunt and gather all of the feelings they can find, even though one of their first presidents was like, "Should we really be hunting and gathering feelings all the time?" But the rest of the dinosaurs were like, "Yeah, man. I never get sick of hunting and gathering feelings. It's really fun, even though I don't know what fun is because I'm a dinosaur and I'm missing that part of my brain. Sign me up for all of the hunting and gathering field trips we got!" Uh, so dinosaurs expanded and expanded across the world, building and eating and building and…

Ellie brainstorms a moment, then sets her whole body to acting out her "report".

But! But when the dinosaurs ran into SeaWorld, the dolphins attacked back! Armed with seals and very loud whistles, they invaded DinosaurLand and made the dinosaurs give up their sports gambling, even though it was an important part of their culture. But the dinosaurs were brave and hungry, and bought humvees to drive over to SeaWorld's house and tell SeaWorld, "Hey! Cut it out! The whole world isn't SeaWorld! This is all of our world, not just the sea's!" So the dinosaurs scared the dolphins with facts and logic, and that's when SeaWorld decided to only be at a few locations and none of them are close to my house, even though I wrote them a letter asking them to change their mind. Peace deals are a very big deal, especially to the dinosaur army.

Ellie settles and resets. She flips the easel to a new blank page.

After the great SeaWorld war of the 1980s, dinosaurs had enough time and scientists to invent the French Industry Revolution, where their cars went from being powered by dumb cavemen's feet to putting bombs in the engine so they could fly to Florida to visit their grandparents every winter, even though their grandparents don't have any teeth. Dinosaurs are

very family-oriented and if you have a problem with one dinosaur, good luck traveling the globe, buddy. Ummm…

Ellie looks around desperately. She grabs some classroom tools.

Dinosaurs have bigger feet than us, so if you look at this ruler—this foot-long ruler—imagine a bunch of these put together and that's a dinosaur's foot! Crazy, right?! That's a lotta footpower. Ummm… Also, dinosaurs invented the stapler during the 90s when their printer kept printing stuff and they couldn't figure out how to turn it off so they had to put the papers together somehow before they flew away and littered all of their moving walkways. Ummm scissors… were invented by humans.

She tosses the scissors, thinks, then flips over a new blank page on the easel.

Dinosaurs spent their not-2000s years creating all of our greatest technologies, from the iPhone to the air fryer. But when one dinosaur family took a vacation to Peru, they accidentally knocked over a tiger's coffee mug, and she said, "Hey! I'm turning some of you into fossils and the rest of you I'll leave alone!" And the dinosaur family couldn't argue because they signed an agreement not to argue in Peru. So that angry tiger made some really neat fossils out of that dinosaur family and sold the fossils to gift shops around the world, and dinosaurs decided to leave Peru alone forever and continue on with their lives around the rest of planet Dinosearth.

Ummm… soooo… for years the dinosaurs lived in peace, building malls and teaching their kids how to go to college and find a boyfriend. But that all changed one fateful day, when the aliens arrived. Seeing the planet ruled by these cool people that look like walking snakes, the aliens told their friends, "Hey guys! I need some backup, can you come help me please?!" So then a bunch of aliens visited Earth, but they did not have a good time. They asked the dinosaurs, "Why isn't Earth a better time?" And the dinosaurs were like, "Well, it was a better time before you guys showed up. No offense." But the aliens took offense. The aliens took so much offense that they took the dinosaurs as hostages to go answer for their crimes in space court, and while they're there, the space judge was like, "What?" But us humans living on the moon were like, "Sweet! Free planet!" So we hopped off the moon and invented paper and cleaned all of the malls and put silly names on them and invented tofu and the sun and sadness and…

Something catches Ellie's eye, stopping her in her tracks.

Oh! Miss Anderson, you took your earbuds out! Because my science report is so good, right? …Oh. Okay. Why? Does the principal want to hear my presentation too?! …Oh.